



◀ THE BLACK DEATH

An explosive outbreak of bubonic plague, a highly contagious disease known as the Black Death, ravaged Europe from 1347 until 1351, killing around a third of the continent's population. It took until the start of the 16th century for Europe's population to recover to its pre-plague level. The horrors of the plague were often represented in the form of dancing skeletons.

▼ THE HUNDRED YEARS' WAR

Beginning in 1337, the Hundred Years' War was a series of battles fought between England and France over English claims to the French throne. The first major battle took place at Crécy (below), where an English army of 12,000 defeated an army of more than 30,000 French soldiers. Ultimately, though, the French won the right to rule unchallenged, and by 1453 had pushed the English out of almost all of France.



CHARLEMAGNE

Leader of the Frankish kingdom (in modern-day France and Germany), Charlemagne (c.748–814) went on to unite large parts of western and central Europe. He was crowned emperor of the Romans in 800 CE.



COIN
DEPICTING
CHARLEMAGNE